

Math or Maths?

Etymology, history, and the case for each

A field built on certainty that cannot agree on its own nickname

Colour key: *green* = a well-established point | *blue* = the opposing view.

Where the word comes from

The disagreement is recent; the word is ancient. “Mathematics” descends from the Ancient Greek *máthēma*, meaning *that which is learnt* — knowledge, study, the things one comes to know. Its parent verb is *manthánein*, “to learn.” From this came the adjective *mathēmatikós*, roughly “disposed to learning” or “pertaining to the mathematical sciences.” The word travelled into English through Latin *mathematica* and Old French *mathématique*.

In English the singular noun *mathematic* is attested from the late fourteenth century; the modern form *mathematics*, carrying the *-ics* ending, settled in around the 1580s. That *-ics* is the same Greek-derived ending found in *physics*, *ethics*, *economics*, and *linguistics*: a fossilised neuter plural (“the mathematical things”) that English now treats as a single subject.

Worth knowing. The root *math-* means *learning*, not *number*. The same root sits inside *polymath* — literally a person of much learning. So at its origin, “mathematics” named not arithmetic but the act of coming to understand. ✓

How “math” and “maths” appeared

Both short forms are products of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries; the full word is far older than either clipping. Written abbreviations came first: American sources use “math.” (with a full stop) early in the 1800s — a letter of 1818 and a student’s diary of 1847 both show it. As a word in its own right, *math* is generally dated to about 1890 in the United States. The British *maths* is attested a little later, from 1911 — a much-cited early instance appears in a letter by the poet Wilfred Owen. Both forms then climbed steeply in their respective regions through the second half of the twentieth century.

Today the split is geographic. *Math* is standard in the United States and Canada; *maths* is standard in the United Kingdom, Ireland, Australia, New Zealand, and much of the English-speaking Commonwealth.

The tidy story is messier than it sounds. The neat “America clipped first, Britain followed” account does not survive close reading. Lewis Carroll — an Englishman and a working mathematician — wrote “Math.” in a diary entry of 1885, and stray American uses of “maths” turn up earlier than the standard British date. The forms were improvised in several places at once; the national preferences hardened only afterwards.

Is “mathematics” singular or plural?

This is the hinge the whole argument turns on. Despite the trailing *s*, “mathematics” is a mass noun and takes a singular verb: *mathematics is*, never *mathematics are*. The *s* looks like a plural marker but does no plural work — much like the second *s* in *chess*, which sounds plural and is not.

The folk reading is the opposite: many speakers see the *s* and quietly assume the word is plural. That misreading is harmless, but it is very likely *why* the *s* was kept in the British clipping in the first place. The instinct to preserve it is the real engine behind “maths.”

Settled point. Whichever clipping you use, the grammar is singular. “Maths is my favourite subject” and “Math is my favourite subject” are both correct; “maths are” is not. The disagreement is purely about the shape of the nickname, never about the verb. ✓

The case for “math”

In favour:

- It matches the grammar. The word is singular, so a singular-looking clipping with no *s* mirrors the verb you actually use (“math is hard”).
- It is consistent with how English clips other *-ics* disciplines: *econ* from economics, *ling* from linguistics, *poli sci* from political science — the trailing *s* is routinely dropped.
- It is the shorter form, by one consonant.

Against: dropping the *s* discards the actual final sound of “mathematics.” As a clipping of the full word, “math” is arguably the less faithful of the two.

The strongest objection. A clipping is meant to stand in for the whole word, and the whole word ends in *s*. By that logic “maths” is the better abbreviation and “math” has simply lopped off a letter that was really there — not a silent ornament, but a sound you hear every time you say “mathematics.”

The case for “maths”

In favour:

- It keeps the final *s* of the full word, so the clipping echoes “mathematics” more closely.
- It follows a familiar British pattern of *s*-keeping clippings, most obviously *stats* from statistics.
- It carries the natural intuition — right or wrong — that the word “feels” plural.

Against: the retained *s* encourages the false belief that “mathematics” is plural, even though “maths” still takes a singular verb. The letter is preserved for a reason that doesn’t actually hold.

The strongest objection. The *s* in “maths” does no grammatical work. It is kept out of an instinct that the word is plural — an instinct the grammar flatly contradicts, since we all say “maths is.” Defended on those grounds, “maths” preserves a misunderstanding, and adds a slightly clumsier *-ths* cluster to pronounce.

So which is correct?

Both. Each is fully standard in its own region, and neither is more logical in any absolute sense — they simply optimise different intuitions. “Math” aligns the nickname with the singular grammar of the word; “maths” keeps the nickname faithful to the full word’s final sound. One privileges how the word *behaves*; the other privileges how the word *ends*. There is no neutral tie-breaker that settles it, which is exactly why the split has lasted.

Bottom line. There is no error here to correct — only a regional convention to follow. The single real rule is consistency with your audience: write “math” for an American reader, “maths” for a British one, and don’t expect either side to be argued out of its habit. ✓